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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 5 — From Structure to Substance

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 5. We move from structure to substance — the four sections of your proposal where grants are won or lost. Complete each section in order. Team discussion prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 5. Review them carefully — each one maps directly to a section of your proposal.

Summarizing Sentence	One sentence at the opening of your proposal that names the need, the organization or partners, the dollar amount requested, and what it will accomplish. Your thesis statement. If a reviewer read nothing else, this sentence should tell the whole story.
Needs Statement	The section of your proposal that makes the case that the problem you are addressing is real, significant, urgent, and demands a response. Grounded in geography, backed by data, and connected directly to your proposed solution.
Target Population	The broad group your program is designed to serve — the general category. Example: “youth ages 12 to 18 in underserved communities.” This shows vision and scope.
Constituency	Who you actually served last year. Specific, documented, real numbers with demographic detail. This shows track record and credibility. Funders want both target population and constituency.
Goal	The big-picture change your program is working toward.

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Objective	Directional but not yet measurable on its own. Example: “We aim to increase academic achievement among youth participants.”
	A specific, measurable, time-bound statement of what change will occur, in how many people, by when, and how it will be measured. Must answer all five of the objective test questions.
	The checklist every objective must pass before it is ready: (1) How many people? (2) Who specifically? (3) By when? (4) How much change? (5) Measured how? If you cannot answer all five, rewrite the objective.
Data-Driven Needs Statement	A needs statement that uses current, specific statistics to prove the problem is real — not just asserted. The more local and recent the data, the stronger the case.
Story + Statistics	A technique for opening the Needs Statement: lead with a brief anecdote about a real person your program served (emotion), then follow immediately with data (evidence). The combination is more persuasive than either alone.
Proposal Coherence	The principle that every section of your proposal — the summarizing sentence, needs statement, constituency description, goals, and objectives — must tell one unified story. The needs justify the goals. The goals drive the objectives. The objectives measure the outcomes.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated proposal excerpt below. The right column explains what each element is doing and why it works. As you read, identify which techniques your own proposal currently uses and which ones are missing.

Sample: Summarizing Sentence, Needs Statement, and Objective

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
[SUMMARIZING SENTENCE] <i>To meet the critical educational and career development needs of opportunity youth in the Eastside corridor, the Youth Forward Collaborative</i>	→ Names the need (“critical educational and career development needs”) → Names the partners / organization

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<i>will utilize the requested \$275,000 to operate a year-round Youth Opportunity Center providing academic coaching, career exploration, and workforce certification for 120 young people ages 16–24.</i>	(“Youth Forward Collaborative”) → States the exact dollar amount (\$275,000) → Explains what it will accomplish and who it serves (120 youth, ages 16–24)
[NEEDS STATEMENT OPENING] <i>At 19, Devon had aged out of foster care with no diploma, no job history, and nowhere to go. He spent four months couch-surfing before a case manager connected him to our program. Today he holds a forklift certification and has been employed full-time for eight months.</i> <i>Devon is not an exception. In [Your City], 1 in 3 young people between 16 and 24 is neither enrolled in school nor working — a population researchers call “opportunity youth.” The economic cost of this disconnection exceeds \$26,000 per young person per year in lost tax revenue and increased public services. Without intervention, the cycle repeats.</i>	→ Opens with a specific participant story — human face on the data → Transitions immediately to a statistic (1 in 3) with a geographic anchor → Economic framing (\$26,000/year) gives funders a cost-of-inaction argument → Closes the paragraph with urgency: “without intervention, the cycle repeats”
[OBJECTIVE] <i>By June 30, 2026, 85% of the 120 enrolled youth who participate in the program for at least 90 days will complete at least one industry-recognized workforce certification, as verified by certification records maintained by program staff and reviewed by an independent evaluator at program close.</i>	→ By when: June 30, 2026 → How many: 120 enrolled youth (85%) → Who specifically: youth participating 90+ days → How much change: one industry-recognized certification → Measured how: certification records + independent evaluator

□ **Team:** As a group, check the annotated objective against the Five-Question Test. Does it answer all five? Then look at your own program’s most recent objective or outcome statement. Does it pass the same test?

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. Then answer the reflection question. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what wins funding.

Module 5

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Comparison 1 — The Summarizing Sentence

☐ Weak

We are applying for funds to support our youth program.

☐ Strong

To meet the needs of the growing number of disconnected youth in our community, our collaborative partners will utilize the requested \$348,250 to provide a safe, education- and career-oriented Youth Opportunity Center serving 90 young people ages 16–24.

☐ What four elements does the strong version include that the weak version is missing entirely?

☐ **Team discussion:** Try drafting your own summarizing sentence right now using the formula: need + organization + dollar amount + what it will accomplish. Share drafts as a group and refine together.

Comparison 2 — The Needs Statement

☐ Weak

There is a significant need for mental health services in our community. Many residents struggle with anxiety and depression, and access to care is limited. Our organization is well-positioned to address this need.

☐ Strong

In [Your County], 1 in 4 adults meets the clinical criteria for a diagnosable mental health condition, yet fewer than 30% receive any form of treatment (SAMHSA, 2023). Among uninsured adults, wait times for outpatient psychiatric care exceed six months. Last year, emergency room visits for mental health crises in our region increased by 22% — a direct consequence of unmet demand. Our mobile crisis response team is the only community-based alternative to emergency hospitalization operating in the area.

☐ List three specific techniques the strong version used that the weak version did not.

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☐ **Team discussion:** What local or regional data does your organization currently have that could anchor your needs statement? Who is responsible for finding updated statistics before your next submission?

Comparison 3 — Target Population vs. Constituency

☐ **Weak**

We serve youth in our community who need support. We plan to serve approximately 200 participants next year.

☐ **Strong**

Target population: Youth ages 14–21 living in households at or below 200% of the federal poverty level in [Your City]. Last year, our constituency included 187 enrolled participants: 61% identified as Hispanic or Latino, 24% as Black or African American, 78% qualified for free or reduced lunch, and 43% were English Language Learners. Of those, 91% completed the program and 84% advanced to the next grade level.

☐ What is the difference between target population and constituency? Write the distinction in your own words.

☐ **Team discussion:** Does your organization track the demographic data needed to write a constituency description this specific? If not, assign someone to audit your current data collection system before the next module.

Comparison 4 — Goals and Objectives

☐ **Weak**

Goal: We will help participants improve their skills. Objective: Participants will show improvement by the end of the program.

☐ **Strong**

Goal: To increase workforce readiness and employment outcomes among program participants. Objective: By September 30, 2026, 80% of the 75 adults who complete at least 80% of program sessions will secure employment within 60 days of graduation, as tracked through monthly follow-up surveys and employer verification for a minimum of six months post-placement.

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- ☐ Apply the Five-Question Test to the strong objective. Write your answer to each question:

☐ **Team discussion:** Write a draft objective for your own program and apply the Five-Question Test together. If any question cannot be answered, the objective is not ready.

Section 4 — Your Proposal Builder

Complete each part below. This is the raw material for your actual proposal sections. Be as specific as possible — vague answers here become vague proposals later.

Part A — Your Summarizing Sentence

Use the formula: [Need] + [Organization/Partners] + [Dollar Amount] + [What It Will Accomplish + Who It Serves]

- ☐ **Draft your summarizing sentence:**

☐ **Team discussion:** Share drafts as a group. Test each one: does it name the need, the organization, the amount, and the outcome? Tighten it until every word is doing work.

★Example — Summarizing sentence formula in action:

To address the growing shortage of certified healthcare workers in [Your Region], [Your Organization] and [Partner Name] will utilize the requested \$195,000 to provide a 12-month Medical Assistant certification program serving 60 adults who are currently unemployed or underemployed.

Part B — Your Needs Statement

- ☐ **Geographic anchor:** Where is this problem happening? (City, county, neighborhood, zip code)

Module 5

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

☐ Write your opening story: a 2–3 sentence anecdote about one real person your program served. Include specific details.

☐ **Team discussion:** Share your stories as a group. Choose the one that most powerfully puts a human face on the data. Protect the participant’s privacy by using a first name only or a pseudonym.

☐ List 3–5 current data points that prove the problem is real, widespread, and urgent. Include source and year for each.

☐ **Tip:** Your data should be as local as possible — county or city level is stronger than national statistics. Check your local United Way, public health department, school district, or city government for recent reports.

☐ In 2–3 sentences, connect the evidence directly to your proposed solution. Why is your program the right response to this data?

☐ **Team:** Assign each team member one data source to research before your next session: local government data, academic research, a national database, a community report, and a news source. Bring your findings to compare.

Part C — Your Constituency Description

☐ Target population (the broad group you intend to serve — age, geography, characteristics):

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☐ **Constituency (who you actually served last year — be specific with numbers and demographics):**

☐ **Total number served last year:**

☐ **Demographic breakdown (age ranges, ethnicities, income levels, or other relevant characteristics):**

☐ **Tip:** *If you do not currently collect demographic data at this level of specificity, start now. This data becomes the foundation of every proposal you write from here forward.*

Part D — Your Goals and Objectives

☐ **Write your program’s overarching goal (the big-picture change you are working toward):**

★Example — Goal:

To increase academic achievement and high school completion rates among youth participants in the program.

Now write at least two measurable objectives. For each one, apply the Five-Question Test using the table below.

OBJECTIVE 1:

☐ **Write your first objective:**

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#	Question	Your answer for this objective
1	How many people will be affected?	
2	Who are they specifically?	
3	By when will this happen?	
4	How much change do you expect?	
5	How will you measure whether it happened?	

OBJECTIVE 2:

☐ Write your second objective:

#	Question	Your answer for this objective
1	How many people will be affected?	
2	Who are they specifically?	
3	By when will this happen?	
4	How much change do you expect?	
5	How will you measure whether it happened?	

☐ **Team:** Review each objective together as a group. If any of the five questions cannot be answered, the objective is not ready for submission. Assign someone to revise before your next session.

Section 5 — Module 5 Self-Audit Checklist

Module 5

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Check every box you can honestly say is true for your current proposal draft. Unchecked boxes are your revision priorities before the next module.

The Summarizing Sentence

- ☐ My summarizing sentence names the specific community need or problem being addressed.
- ☐ It identifies my organization and/or collaborative partners.
- ☐ It states the exact dollar amount requested.
- ☐ It explains what the funds will accomplish and how many people will be served.
- ☐ It is one sentence. Every word is doing work.

The Needs Statement

- ☐ My needs statement is about the problem — not about my organization.
- ☐ It is grounded in a specific geography (city, county, neighborhood).
- ☐ It opens with a specific participant story that puts a human face on the data.
- ☐ It includes at least three current, local data points with sources and years.
- ☐ It establishes urgency — the problem is happening now and demands a response.
- ☐ It connects the evidence directly to my proposed solution.

Constituency Description

- ☐ I have described my target population (the broad group I intend to serve).
- ☐ I have described my constituency (who I actually served last year) with specific numbers and demographics.
- ☐ The numbers and demographics are current (from the most recently completed program year).
- ☐ My constituency description shows alignment with the funder's target population and priorities.

Goals and Objectives

- ☐ I have written at least one program goal that describes the big-picture change I am working toward.
- ☐ I have written at least two objectives that are specific, measurable, and time-bound.
- ☐ Each objective answers all five questions: How many? In whom? By when? How much change? Measured how?

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- ☐ My objectives directly address the needs I described in my Needs Statement.
- ☐ My goals and objectives are consistent with my summarizing sentence.

Proposal Coherence

- ☐ Every section of my proposal tells the same story — the need, the population, the goal, and the measurement are all consistent.
- ☐ A reviewer could read my summarizing sentence alone and understand the full proposal.
- ☐ There are no contradictions between my data, my constituency numbers, and my objectives.

My revision priorities before the next module:

☐ **Team:** Assign each revision item a team member and a due date. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.

*“The strongest proposals don’t just describe good intentions.
They prove, with specificity and data,
that the work is necessary, achievable, and already happening.”*
— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 5